
Embrace Diversity

Map out the differences in interests, power, and knowledge within your team and make optimal use of your diversity. Learn here how to leverage this diversity to improve collaboration and develop more creative solutions.

In a transdisciplinary collaboration, there are many differences among team members. Differences are often seen as challenging, but they can also be beneficial. By recognizing, valuing, and actively using these differences, you can improve collaboration and outcomes. These differences can be divided into three categories: interests, power, and knowledge (Smeenk, 2023).

Diversity in Interests

As a team member, you participate in a transdisciplinary project for various reasons, such as personal, financial, or work-related motivations. Ask yourself: who has which interests and why? These interests are not always visible. If you do not articulate them, the process can become very complex and frustrating, especially since you often work towards an unclear goal. Speak up and help resolve conflicts constructively.

Diversity in Power

In a transdisciplinary collaboration, you almost always encounter unequal power dynamics. A person's role, network, knowledge, or personality partly determines their power. If these power dynamics are not acknowledged or discussed, it can result in frustrations. However, power can also be harnessed (Oskam, 2023). Dreaming together about the future and your common goal is the first step. Discuss how achieving the common goal changes the position of all parties: you want to create a new playing field. This means that powerful players must give up and change things in their habits or responsibilities: the common goal is paramount.

Diversity in Knowledge

The different types of knowledge that all team members bring to the table is the foundation of your project: combining scientific and practical insights that contribute to

system knowledge (understanding the current reality), goal knowledge (visualizing the desired outcome), and transformation knowledge (transitioning from system knowledge to goal knowledge) (Oskam, 2023). Participants bring different kinds of knowledge from their experiences or lifestyles. Make clear what each person's knowledge, expertise, and experience are and what type of knowledge they can and want to contribute.